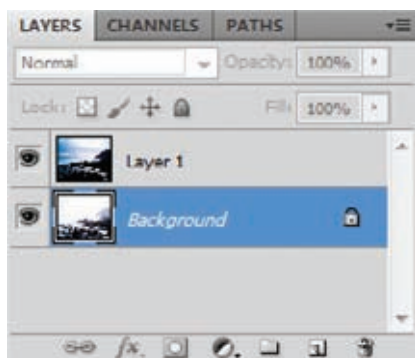
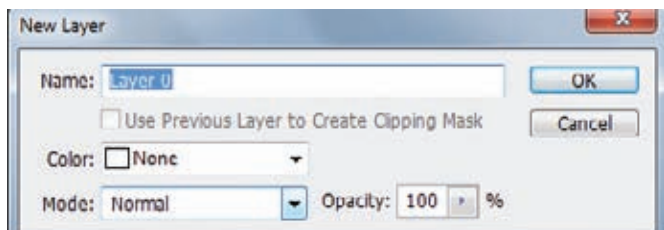




Get both the images as different layers into the same file

You can do this by right-clicking the image layer and duplicating it into the other file or by dragging and dropping the image into the other file. Make sure both images are in different layers and none of them is a background image. You can convert a background to a layer by double clicking on it from the Layers Panel and clicking OK.



Double click on the background to convert it to a normal layer

We shall start by adding the layer with the darker exposure to the image with the lighter exposure, so that the darker one is on top of the lighter one. Make sure that both the layers are perfectly aligned by moving the layer after clicking 'V' to get the move tool and then move the layer holding the [Shift] key to perfectly position the layer in the image window.

Adding a Layer Mask to the top Layer

The next step is the most important step in this process. We shall add a layer mask on the top layer to mask the regions that do not have a good exposure and show only the good parts of the layer. The

mask will cover up the bad regions and will let the regions with better exposure in the layer below blend into the final image.

Now if there are three or more images with varying exposure instead of just two like we have taken in this illustration, based on the type of the images you are blending and the complexity of the edges in each of them you will be using the same process on each of them adding a mask to each of the layers on top. The mask makes sure that only the good parts from every layer are visible.

To add a mask to a layer, first make sure the layer is selected from the Layers Panel. Then click the Add Vector Mask button at the bottom of the

Layers Panel or add a Layer Mask from the Layers Menu. A mask which is displayed by a white thumbnail appears next to the layer thumbnail. The white colour of the mask indicates that the mask is opaque. Painting a region of this mask black makes it transparent depending on the amount of black and the layer below becomes visible through the mask. The amount of grey on it indicates how transparent or opaque the mask is. So the mask transparency changes based on the colour range between white and black painted onto the mask

Paint the Layer Mask

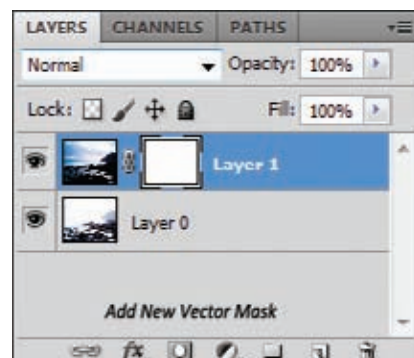
Now select the Brush Tool from the tools menu on the left or hit the B key on your keyboard. Set

the Foreground Colour to Black and from the Brushes options bar on top set the Opacity of the Brush to 50%. Select a soft edged brush or just change the hardness of a solid round brush to zero. Choose a Brush size large enough to be able to paint over the entire bottom part of the image. In this case, we do this since the view of the rocks where there is good detail is only from the lighter image. Now select the Layer Mask and paint over it using this brush.

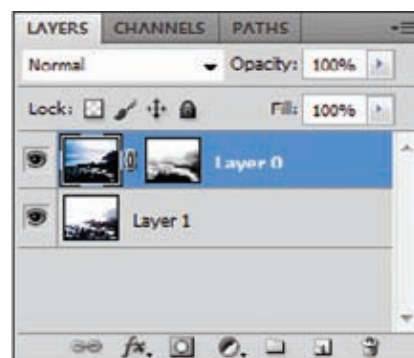
Keep repeating the brush strokes multiple times to show more colour tones from the layer below. Reduce the brush size if needed and work on other parts of the layer as required. In this case, the entire bottom of the mask is painted black and the other regions where the rocks meet the water should be painted a little more carefully. If you need to reverse any of the changes on the mask, just change the brush colour to white and paint over the region of the mask you want to change or revert back.

Add an Adjustment Layer

In this particular illustration we lowered the opacity of the brush even further to 20% and painted over the region of the hill so that it blends properly with the image below. Now we will try to bring out even greater contrast by adding an adjustment layer on top.



Click the Add Vector Mask button with the Layer selected



Select the layer and paint using the brush

[Alt]+Click on the Create New Adjustment Layer Icon, i.e. click on it keeping the Alt key on the keyboard pressed and then choose to add a Curves Adjustment Layer. Make sure you have checked the Create a Clipping Mask checkbox and then click OK. Make sure to adjust the curves as shown in the image. Ticking the Clipping Mask makes sure that



Add a new Curves Layer on top of the layer